

GP Prescribing of Stop Smoking Medications

Service	GP Prescribing of Stop Smoking Medications
Authority Lead	Ian Tyson and Ruby Entwistle
Provider Lead	GP practices
Period	01 October 2025 – 30 September 2028 (with option to extend to 2031)
Date of Review	01 October 2026

1. Population Needs

1.1 National/local context and evidence base

1.1.1 Smoking is the single greatest cause of preventable illness and premature death in the U.K.

1.1.2 More than any other identifiable factor, smoking contributes to the gap in life expectancy between the most deprived and the most affluent.

1.1.3 The prevalence of smoking is estimated as 10.8% in Devon and 15.4% in Torbay. For those in routine and manual occupations this increases to 21.2% in Devon and 27.3% in Torbay. This figure varies considerably across socio-economic and geographical lines which heavily influences smoking related morbidity and mortality in these areas.

1.1.4 Tobacco smoke contains many chemicals that are harmful to both smokers and non-smokers. Smoking harms nearly every organ in the body and breathing even a little tobacco smoke can be harmfulⁱ.

1.1.5 Helping a patient to stop smoking is one of the most cost effective of all medical interventions.

1.1.6 Evidence demonstrates that people wishing to stop smoking are three times more likely to be successful when supported by appropriate medication or nicotine replacement products alongside motivational support provided by a trained stop smoking adviserⁱⁱ; a Cochrane Review showed varenicline and cytisine to be the most effective quit aids, alongside nicotine e-cigarettesⁱⁱⁱ. Combination nicotine replacement therapy (NRT) had similar levels of effectiveness, with single use NRT and bupropion still showing positive benefits with high certainty evidenceⁱⁱ.

1.1.7 NICE Guideline NG209 outlines that medicinally licensed products should be made available to adults who smoke, including varenicline, cytisine, bupropion and NRT^{iv}.

2. Key Service Outcomes

2.1 The service is delivered in accordance with applicable formularies in Devon and Torbay.

2.2 Patients who successfully stop smoking through this Locally Commissioned Service will contribute towards an aspirational target of the Department of Health's recommended 5% of people stopping smoking per year.

2.3 In addition, treating patients who are tobacco dependent helps in the delivery of several core health and well-being outcomes (below).

Direct public health outcome indicators	Indirect public health outcome indicators
2.03: Smoking at the time of delivery	4.03: Mortality from preventable causes
2.14: Smoking prevalence – adults	4.04: Premature mortality from all cardiovascular disease
	4.05 Premature mortality from Cancer

2.4 Reducing the prevalence of smoking among priority populations, including routine and manual workers, people with serious mental illness, black and minority ethnic groups and disadvantaged communities, will have a significant impact in terms of reducing health inequalities. A high level of intervention is vital to deliver effective, cross-social group reach on this vital public health issue.

2.5 The gold standard provision of support for treating tobacco dependence is outlined in the NCSCCT standard treatment programme^v. Behavioural support alongside the medication prescribing outlined in this specification should follow this programme.

3. Scope

3.1 Aims and objectives of service

3.1.1 The main aim of this contract is to enable clients who are receiving behavioural support to stop smoking through local stop smoking services in Devon and Torbay, to access to prescribed medication, currently unavailable through any other route. These services include the specialist stop smoking services and pharmacy services. Where practices are commissioned to provide behavioural support already, the fee for this service includes the costs for undertaking the prescribing of applicable stop smoking medications.

3.1.2 The objective is to enable safe, timely and equitable access to Varenicline, Bupropion and Cytisine, for patients who are clinically appropriate to receive these medications.

3.1.3 This service will work alongside a similar service in community pharmacy utilising a Patient Group Direction (PGD). The pharmacy PGD includes some exclusions where

people are taking medications which are impacted by cessation of tobacco use; the referral pathway for these patients looking to access prescribed medications is into this service.

3.2 Service description/pathway

This service is not applicable to patients who receive behavioural support from an in-house practice adviser (prescribing costs are included in the fee for this commissioned service), or where they receive no behavioural support at all.

3.2.1 The Provider (GP Practice) will:

- Make provision for a GP to undertake an assessment of suitability for a prescription having received a letter of recommendation from a pharmacy or specialist Stop Smoking Service.
- Where the clinical assessment confirms the patient is appropriate to receive the medication, the GP practice will issue a prescription, in a timely manner.
- As part of the assessment for suitability, discuss medication side effects and risks with the patient.
- Provide prescriptions for Varenicline and Bupropion on a regime that is clinically appropriate for the patient and in line with prescribing guidelines. Where Cytisine is requested, provide a prescription on a regime that is clinically appropriate for the patient and in line with prescribing guidelines.
- Review dosage for relevant medications at appropriate time points, where a patient has existing medication which is impacted by reduced use of or cessation of tobacco ([Drugs affected by smoking cessation | Prescribing information | Smoking cessation | CKS | NICE](#)).
- Where patient is unsuitable for the medication, this will be communicated back to the local Stop Smoking Service using the referrer information contained on the letter of recommendation. See Appendix A for details of specialist stop smoking services.
- Record the letter of recommendation received by the surgery from the local Stop Smoking Service, for audit purposes.
- Record quit outcome on patient's clinical record and update smoking status.

3.2.2 The local Stop Smoking Services will:

- Assess the patient's motivation to quit smoking and learning from any previous quit attempts.
- Describe and discuss pharmacotherapy options for treating tobacco dependence with the patient and support them to decide upon the product most suitable to them.
- Provide a letter of recommendation to the GP surgery via post or secure email should Varenicline, Bupropion or Cytisine be selected as the preferred and suitable treatment option. The letter will be sent in a secure manner (e.g. NHS

Mail) contain sufficient assurances that the patient will be provided with behavioural support in line with the NCSCT Standard Treatment Programme^v.

- Inform the patient that they will need to continue receiving behavioural support from the local Stop Smoking Service whilst taking this medication.
- Advise the patient they may need to attend a clinical assessment by their GP.
- Advise and support the patient to set a quit date at the appropriate time relevant to the medication being prescribed:
 - Varenicline: 7 to 14 days after initiation
 - Bupropion: 7 to 14 days after initiation
 - Cytisine: no later than 5 days after initiation
- Ensure the patient is aware of possible side effects of the medication.
- Ensure the patient is aware that four prescription charges apply (unless exempt).
- Record patient's details and medication used on their electronic client relationship management (CRM) system.
- Record adverse reactions to medication on patient's electronic record held by the local Stop Smoking Service and alert GP of any adverse side effects.
- Report any adverse reactions using the 'Yellow Card' reporting system.
- Send details of the quit outcome to the GP when patient has been assessed for inclusion on the patient record held by the GP surgery.

3.2.4 The Commissioner (Public Health teams in Devon and Torbay Councils) will:

- remunerate the practice for each course of Varenicline, Cytisine or Bupropion prescribed to a patient, up to a maximum of four courses a year, unless more is clinically appropriate.

3.3 Population covered

3.3.1 This specification covers residents in Devon and Torbay local authority areas, who are being supported by local authority commissioned stop smoking services.

3.4 Exclusion criteria

3.4.1 This service is not available to:

- Pregnant patients.
- Patients under the age of 18.
- Patients living outside of Devon or Torbay local authority areas.

3.4.2 Additional exclusion criteria/contraindications will apply to each medication, as detailed in the British National Formulary.

3.5 Interdependencies with other services

3.5.1 This Specification has an interdependency with the local specialist and pharmacy-based Stop Smoking Services in Devon and Torbay.

4. Applicable Service Standards

4.1 Applicable national standards

- [NICE Guidance - NG209](#)
- [NCSCT Standard Treatment Programme](#)
- [British National Formulary](#)

5. Pricing

5.1 The costs for this service are all inclusive and includes GP prescribing time (20 minutes) and administration time (5 minutes) and covers the entire course of prescribing for stop smoking prescribed medications.

The total fee available for this service is as follows:

20 mins GP time = £35.74

5 mins admin time = £1.72

Total = £37.46

Specialist Stop Smoking Service for Devon County Council Residents

Stop for Life Devon

<https://stopforlifedevon.org/>

For General Enquiries, contact the following details:

- Direct local number: 0800 122 3866
- info@stopforlifedevon.org

For Referrals

Stop For Life Devon can provide clients with specialist support to quit smoking.

- stopforlife.devon@nhs.net (closely monitored, secure mailbox)
- Online referral form available at: <https://stopforlifedevon.org/get-started/>
- Direct local number: 0800 122 3866

Specialist Stop Smoking Service for Torbay Council Residents

Your Health Torbay

Stop Smoking - Your Health Torbay

For General Enquiries, contact the following details:

- 01803 422 422
- Yourhealth.torbay@nhs.net

For Referrals

Professional Referral - Your Health Torbay

References

ⁱ ASH, 2025. *Facts at a glance*. Available from: [Facts-At-A-Glance-Fact-Sheet.pdf](#) [Accessed 29 April 2025].

ⁱⁱ West, R. and Papadakis, S., 2019. *Stop Smoking Services: Increased Chances of Quitting*. Available from: [stop smoking services effectiveness 2024-25 v1](#) [Accessed 29 April 2025].

ⁱⁱⁱ Lindson, N et al, 2023. *Pharmacological and electronic cigarette interventions for smoking cessation in adults: component network meta-analyses*. Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews. <https://doi.org/10.1002/14651858.CD015226.pub2> [Accessed 28 Jan. 2025].

^{iv} NICE, 2025. *Tobacco: preventing uptake, promoting quitting and treating dependence*. Available from: [Treating tobacco dependence | Tobacco: preventing uptake, promoting quitting and treating dependence | Guidance | NICE](#) [Accessed 29 April 2025].

^v NCSCT, 2019. *Standard Treatment Programme*. Available from: [NCSCT STP LR v7.fh11](#) [Accessed 29 April 2025].